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VISION · WORDPRESS VS A CUSTOM BUILD

Project Rogers Edge

The vision for 6311arts.com

Client Sponsor: **Holly King** Architect: **Robert Felkins**

AGENDA

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What we will cover today

From the WordPress site of today to the platform 6311 will run on

1. **Where we started**
   The WordPress site 6311 runs today
2. **The options we weighed**
   Trim WordPress, go headless, or build custom
3. **Why we went custom**
   How the decision was made, and what tipped it
4. **The vision**
   What 6311 gets from a platform built for how it works
5. **How it's built**
   Architecture, principles and the path to launch

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AGENDA · 01 OF 05

Where we started

The WordPress site 6311 runs today

A site that already sells art, classes and memberships, held together by about 25 plugins.

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The WordPress site today

WHAT IT DOES

It already sells

- 780+ original works by local artists in the shop
- Classes sold as FooEvents tickets in WooCommerce
- Memberships and MailPoet newsletter sign-ups

THE STACK

About 25 plugins deep

- Astra Pro and Beaver Builder: two layout systems
- WooCommerce, FooEvents, Jetpack, MailPoet, CPT UI…
- Each one an update, a license and a door left open

THE AUDIT

What October 15 found

- Public user list with 6 login names
- About page hidden from Google
- Privacy Policy and Terms link to #

STAFF TIME

What it costs the team

- Front-desk Square and WooCommerce don't talk
- Prices and stock entered twice
- Changes depend on whoever knows the plugins

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The options we weighed

Trim WordPress, go headless, or build custom

Three honest paths, judged on what matters to a small nonprofit: staff time, running cost and risk.

02 · THE OPTIONS

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Three paths we looked at

OPTION A

Keep and trim WordPress

- Cut to about 8 plugins; retire Beaver Builder
- Lowest cost now; plugins do the hard parts
- WooCommerce and front-desk Square stay apart

OPTION B

Headless WordPress + Angular

- Prototyped Oct 18: fast SSR front end, strong SEO
- WordPress stays the back end staff edit in
- Two systems to run, and the plugins remain

OPTION C

Custom: Angular SSR + Studio

- A closed CMS built for 6311's content
- Square owns money and stock, online and in person
- More to build up front; nothing to patch after

WHAT WE WEIGHED

The test for each option

- Can staff run it without a developer?
- What does it cost to own each month?
- How exposed is it, and who keeps it patched?

02 · SIDE BY SIDE

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WordPress vs a custom Angular SSR build

WORDPRESS, TRIMMED

- ✓ *Lowest upfront cost; shop, tickets and email work out of the box*
- ✓ *Every plugin is an update, a license and a door left open*
- ✓ *WooCommerce and the front-desk Square stay two systems*

ANGULAR SSR, CUSTOM

- ★ *One record of truth: Studio owns content, Square owns money*
- ★ *Closed CMS with no plugins, themes or page builder to patch*
- ★ *Fast server-rendered pages, SEO built in, about $105–125/mo*

The October 15 audit recommended keeping WordPress. The next section shows what changed.

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Why we went custom

How the decision was made, and what tipped it

The audit said keep WordPress. Square at the front desk, plugin risk and staff time said otherwise.

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Two weeks from audit to plan

OCT 15

Audit and honest advice

- Good, bad and ugly review of 6311arts.com
- Advice: keep WordPress, trim the plugins
- Open worry: the plugin stack keeps growing

OCT 18

The prototype

- Angular 22 SSR site in the CSoon design, 12 pages
- JSON-LD, sitemap and 301s from old URLs
- Still reading WordPress: Option B, proven

OCT 18

The architecture

- Closed CMS, API, gateway and worker
- Two-way Square sync designed field by field
- Built with Claude Code and SCRUB prompts

OCT 29

The statement of work

- Custom CMS, Square payments, Azure hosting
- WordPress retired after a short parallel run
- UAT in December and January

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What tipped the decision

STAFF

One place to work

- Classes, shows, artists, shop and pages in Studio
- Draft, schedule, preview, publish
- No plugin screens, no page builder

MONEY

Square everywhere

- Website and front-desk POS share one catalog
- A piece sold in person shows sold online
- Class seats are Square stock, always current

RISK

Nothing to patch

- No plugins or themes to update or exploit
- One public front door; staff sign in with 2FA
- Card data never touches the site

COST

Cheap to own

- About $105–125/mo hosting; dev scales to zero
- No plugin licenses or agency dependence
- Code, docs and runbooks in 6311's GitHub

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What we accepted to get there

BUILD

More work up front

- Shop, tickets and members built, not installed
- Square sync is the largest piece of the build
- Delivered in two-week milestones to January

CLOSED

New content types need a developer

- Studio has only the screens 6311 needs
- That's the point: nothing extra to break
- New types are small, documented changes

HOSTING

6311 owns its hosting

- Azure instead of WordPress.com's managed plan
- CI deploys, monitoring and backups set up
- Runbooks in the Knowledge Base

SQUARE

Square's rules apply

- Staff change price and stock in Square only
- Memberships: $1 minimum and no bank payments
- Refunds stay in the Square dashboard

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The vision

What 6311 gets from a platform built for how it works

Staff publish in minutes, Square stays in sync everywhere, and visitors book and buy on the page.

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What changes for each person

STAFF

Publish in minutes

- Add a class and its sessions, then schedule it
- Preview before anything goes live
- Prices and seats managed in Square

VISITORS

Fast, findable, buyable

- Mobile-first pages that rank in search
- Live seats and "sold out" on every class
- Pay on the page: card, Apple Pay, Google Pay

MEMBERS

Join and manage online

- Sign up with a saved card
- See status and renewal; update the card
- Member class discount at checkout

ARTISTS

A page worth sharing

- Profile with photo, bio and their own links
- Available work pulled live from the shop
- Sign in to submit new work

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Classes, the biggest change

TODAY

- ✓ *FooEvents products in a WooCommerce shop, out of date order*
- ✓ *"8 in stock" and only the first date of a 5-week course*
- ✓ *Front-desk sales and website seats tracked separately*

TOMORROW

- ★ *A calendar by date, type and level, with every session listed*
- ★ *"3 spots left" from Square, online and at the front desk*
- ★ *Book and pay on the page; listings show richly in Google*

The same pattern runs through the shop, exhibitions, artists and memberships.

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How it's built

Architecture, principles and the path to launch

A closed CMS, Square as the record for money, and one model that runs on a laptop and publishes to Azure.

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The pieces and what they do

EXPERIENCE

Public site & Studio

- Angular SSR site: speed and search
- Studio: only the screens staff need
- One shared 6311 design system

PLATFORM

Gateway & API

- One front door: sessions, security, rate limits
- ASP.NET Core API with staff and member sign-in
- Every rule tested, layer by layer

INTEGRATION

Worker & Square sync

- Outbox: nothing lost, nothing sent twice
- Signed webhooks keep the site current
- Reconciler catches anything missed

FOUNDATION

Data, media & Azure

- SQL content, blob media, image renditions
- Runs on a laptop, publishes to Azure
- WordPress import with every URL redirected

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Rules that don't bend

OWNERSHIP

Square owns money and stock

- Studio owns names, copy, images and dates
- Starting price sent once, at creation
- Webhooks never trusted; current state fetched

RELIABILITY

Every side effect is queued

- Square calls, emails and images go via the outbox
- Saved in the same transaction as the change
- Idempotency keys on every Square write

SECURITY

One public origin

- Browsers hold only an HttpOnly session cookie
- The API trusts only the gateway's internal token
- Staff sign in with two-factor authentication

PORTABILITY

Laptop to Azure, one model

- Runs offline with a local Square stand-in
- Publishes to Azure Container Apps from CI
- No Azure or Square account needed to develop

05 · DELIVERY

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How it gets built and handed over

METHOD

Claude Code + SCRUB prompts

- Small, reviewable prompts: plan, approve, build
- Scope, Constraint, Restriction, Utilization, Behavior
- Rules, skills and hooks keep every change on-pattern

PHASES

Seven build phases

- Platform, Studio, public site, WordPress import
- Square sync, checkout and memberships
- Azure publish, hardening and cutover

QUALITY

Reviewed at every step

- 8 reviewer agents: security, outbox, contracts…
- Tests per layer, Square contract suite, Playwright
- Deploys only from CI, with approval for prod

HANDOVER

6311 owns everything

- Code in 6311's GitHub with decision records
- Knowledge Base, runbooks and an admin guide
- Square, Azure and email accounts in 6311's name

05 · OPEN DECISIONS

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What we still need to decide

EMAIL

Newsletter platform

- The SOW names Kit; the build exports until chosen
- Compare cost, list size and ease for staff
- Decision with Holly and Michael in Milestone 1

CHECKOUT

On-page or Square-hosted

- Architecture: pay on the page (Web Payments SDK)
- SOW: Square-hosted checkout
- On-page widens PCI scope; confirm with Square

MEMBERS

Member class discount

- How the discount is applied at checkout
- Square subscriptions: $1 minimum, no ACH
- Decided during the Square build

PLATFORM

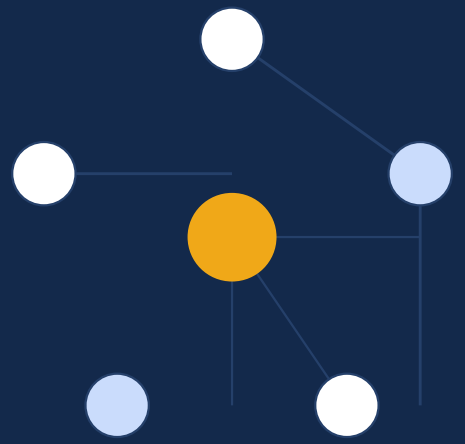
Smaller calls

- Redis: managed (~$15–20/mo) or container
- Square archive policy for retired items

LET'S TALK

Questions?

Push on the ideas, the trade-offs and the order of the work — that's what this conversation is for.



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